

The Reservist State: How Geopolitical Rivalry Undermines Women's Representation*

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Abstract

Despite global gains in women's political representation, several democracies, including the United States, Israel, and South Korea, continue to lag behind. This paper asks whether protracted interstate rivalry helps explain this pattern. I develop a theory of *reservist values*, arguing that geopolitical rivalry cultivates three critical social values—deference to authority, civic duty toward national defense, and trust in military institutions—to foster civic readiness for national contingencies. These values channel confidence toward traditional leadership prototypes and their predominantly male occupants, making citizens who hold them more skeptical of women's leadership. I test this argument using an original multi-country survey in five democracies, a cross-national survey of over 120,000 respondents, and electoral outcomes in 83 countries. Results show that citizens in rivalry states hold stronger reservist values, and that reservist values predict skepticism toward women's leadership above and beyond conventional measures of militarism. These attitudinal differences are reflected in broader political outcomes, as rivalry states exhibit greater voter-level bias against women's leadership and lower levels of women's representation. By revealing how external pressures shape the gendered distribution of political power, this study advances our understanding of women's political representation in an era of enduring global insecurity.

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Democracies have witnessed remarkable gains in women's political representation over the past few decades. The average share of women in parliament has more than doubled globally, and a growing number of states have achieved gender parity or beyond in legislatures and cabinets (UN 2026). Women's political gains have, in turn, improved governance both domestically and internationally, from strengthening the economy (Dahlum, Knutsen, and Mechkova 2022) and reducing affective polarization (Adams et al. 2023) to curbing states' military actions (Kikuta 2026) and sustaining peace (Shair-Rosenfield and Wood 2017).

Despite these gains, stubborn resisters remain. The United States has women holding just 28% of seats in the 119th Congress, well below the Americas regional average of 36% and ranking 84th globally. Israel similarly lags, with women's representation in the Knesset stagnating at around a quarter for nearly a decade. South Korea (21%), Japan (16%), Greece (24%), and India (14%) reflect the same broader pattern, continuing to lag behind the global trend toward gender parity in parliament. While these cases differ substantially in the institutional, socioeconomic, and cultural factors that scholars typically invoke to explain women's underrepresentation (Alexander and Off 2025; Paxton, Hughes, and Barnes 2025; Verge and de la Fuente 2014; Verge and Astudillo 2019), they share one notable feature: protracted interstate rivalry. This raises three central questions: does geopolitical rivalry help explain why some democracies continue to lag behind in women's access to positions of power? If so, why does rivalry undermine women's representation? Finally, what measures can increase support for women political leaders in countries engaged in protracted rivalry?

Geopolitical rivalry, I argue, undermines women's representation by cultivating a long-term political culture that prepares citizens for militarized escalation while channeling confidence toward male leadership. Rivalry permeates public discourse and cultivates social values aligned with persistent insecurity (Bar-Tal and Halperin 2013; Halperin and Pliskin 2015), creating a polity that operates on the logic of a reserve force, whose members are expected to remain ready for mobilization even in the absence of an immediate threat. I conceptualize the distinctive set of values that emerges from this condition as *reservist values*. The reservist values consist of three pillars:

(i) conformity to hierarchical authority and vertical chains of command in everyday interpersonal interactions; (ii) emphasis on shared civic responsibility and mutual obligation around collective defense; and (iii) trust in military institutions that issue and enforce collective commands. Each pillar channels confidence toward existing power structures and their predominantly male occupants (Accorsi and Krebs 2025; Cheryan and Markus 2020; Mueller 1985), rendering those who hold these values more skeptical of women's leadership.

I examine this argument across four studies. Drawing on the Integrated Values Survey covering more than 120,000 respondents across democracies worldwide, Study 1 shows that citizens in rivalry states exhibit stronger reservist values across all three pillars, and that each pillar is associated with lower support for women's political leadership. Study 2 then examines whether these attitudinal differences are reflected in broader political outcomes. It shows that citizens in rivalry states exhibit greater bias against women political leaders, and that this bias is reflected in lower levels of women's legislative representation. Study 3 uses an original multi-country survey conducted in South Korea, Taiwan, the United States, Finland, and Denmark to develop and validate an original 8-item reservist values scale, showing that the scale strongly predicts skepticism toward women's political leadership even after accounting for alternative explanations such as militarism, right-wing authoritarianism, sexism, and conservative ideology. Finally, Study 4 examines whether this bias can be reduced through an original survey experiment in South Korea, a country that has been engaged in a protracted geopolitical rivalry for more than seventy years, by testing two strategies for reducing bias against women political leaders, even among those who strongly endorse reservist values.

This research advances a broad range of literature, including women's representation, the politics of interstate rivalry, and the domestic consequences of international relations. First, this study identifies rivalry as a distinct political environment that shapes women's representation. Existing studies on gender and conflict document that acute threats hinder women's access to power and activate stereotypes that women lack masculine-coded leadership traits (Hadzic and Tavits 2021a; Lawless 2004; Itzkovitch-Malka 2024), even when their actual performance in office

demonstrates otherwise (Humayun 2024; Imamverdiyeva and Shea 2022). Yet far less attention has been paid to sustained interstate hostility. Building on a small set of studies that examine prolonged threat environments (Kim and Kang 2022; Schroeder 2017) and gendered political culture (Alexander and Off 2025), this study shows that protracted rivalry exerts enduring effects on gender equality by cultivating reservist values. At the same time, this study advances understanding of the politics of geopolitical rivalry and its domestic consequences. Prior research has explored the impact of rivalry on anti-immigrant sentiment (Wimmer et al. 2024), genocide and politicide (Uzonyi 2018), leadership turnover (Colaresi, Rasler, and Thompson 2008), state capacity building (Gibler and Miller 2014; Han and Thies 2019; Lu and Thies 2013; Thies 2005), and domestic cohesion and centralization (Bak, Chávez, and Rider 2020; Mari et al. 2022). This study extends the literature by identifying women's political representation as a consequential domestic outcome, laying the groundwork for future research on the broader gendered implications of geopolitical rivalry. Finally, this study speaks to a growing literature on strategies for improving women's political representation. While researchers have worked to identify interventions that could increase support for women leaders (Ofosu, Seeberg, and Wahman 2026), little is known about what enables states to maintain, or even expand, women's representation during periods of external tension. Understanding these conditions is essential for advancing gender equality in an era of enduring global insecurity.

Women's Leadership in Hostile Security Environment

A substantial body of research demonstrates hostile security environment constrain women's access to positions of power (Hadzic and Tavits 2021a; Holman, Merolla, and Zechmeister 2016; Itzkovitch-Malka 2024; O'Brien and Piscopo 2023). In times of heightened insecurity, threatened voters prioritize leadership traits conventionally associated with masculinity (Hasty and Maner 2025; Falk and Kenski 2006; O'Brien and Piscopo 2023), evaluating women as less fit to govern than their male counterparts (Bauer 2015; Hadzic and Tavits 2021a; Huddy and Terkildsen 1993).

Lawless (2004) finds that, in the aftermath of the September 11 terrorist attack, citizens in the United States expressed a stronger preference for traditionally masculine leadership traits, perceiving men as better equipped to handle emerging security threats. Experimental evidence by Holman, Merolla, and Zechmeister (2016) and Itzkovitch-Malka (2024) similarly demonstrates that security threats tend to erode support for women leaders.

While this body of work provides compelling evidence that security environment shapes attitudes toward women's leadership, it leaves two dimensions of insecurity theoretically ambiguous: continuity and anticipation. First, existing studies capture insecurity as a discrete event, such as a war or a terrorist attack, leaving open how insecurity operates when it persists over long periods of time. Effects of acute crises often fade once the immediate threat subsides. Bove, Efthymoulou, and Pickard (2024) show that the effect of terrorism on public sentiment is short-lived, returning to "homeostasis" even on the most immediate measures of terrorism. Efthymoulou, Pickard, and Bove (2024) similarly find that terrorist threat strengthens British identification but that this effect disappears within 45 days as the threat dissipates. A full account of continuity requires understanding how citizens' leadership preferences develop when insecurity accumulates into a durable feature of political life.

Second, existing studies operationalize insecurity through the experience of violence, leaving open whether insecurity more broadly defined, as the sustained threat of conflict whether or not it materializes into violence, similarly undermines women's representation. Identifying whether these effects hold only where violence has occurred, or extend to states that anticipate conflict for a prolonged period without directly experiencing it, requires examining both forms of insecurity together. Long-standing interstate rivalries provide a valuable setting to do so, as rivalry may persist for decades independent of whether it erupts into major war (Israel-Iran and India-Pakistan), or remains unresolved without one (US-China, Taiwan-China, and Greece-Turkey). Rivalry thus allows us to develop a broader theory of how insecurity shapes gendered leadership preferences by accounting for both its continuity and its anticipation.

Geopolitical Rivalry as a Protracted Security Environment

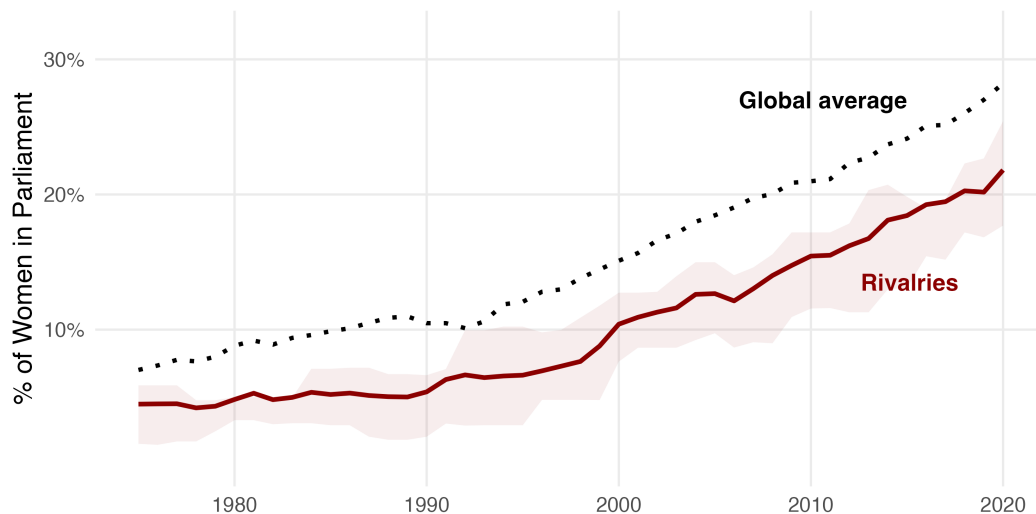
Interstate rivalries have spanned centuries and continents. Unlike single disputes or wars, rivalries are enduring relationships of antagonism in which states come to regard one another as persistent threats. Myrick (2021, p.927) characterizes rivalry as a “competitive relationship that could become militarized.” Diehl, Goertz, and Gallegos (2021, p.610) similarly define rivalry as a protracted state of enmity in which “states see one another as enemies and competitors.” Across these accounts, the core feature of rivalry is a *continuing* state of antagonism between countries that develops and endures over time (Diehl, Goertz, and Gallegos 2021; Thompson, Sakuwa, and Suhas 2022). As of 2020, rivalries persist across much of the world, including the Middle East and North Africa (e.g., Syria and Jordan, Iran and the United Arab Emirates, Iran and Israel), Eastern Africa (Ethiopia and Sudan, the Democratic Republic of Congo and Rwanda, Kenya and Somalia), Southeastern Europe (Greece and Turkey, Russia and Ukraine, Armenia and Azerbaijan), East and Southeast Asia (China and India, North and South Korea, China and Taiwan), Latin America (Colombia and Venezuela, Bolivia and Chile, Guyana and Venezuela), and South Asia (Afghanistan and Pakistan, India and Pakistan) (Thompson, Sakuwa, and Suhas 2022). Rivalry, in short, has been a consistent feature of international politics.

The prolonged interstate hostility produces lasting domestic political and social consequences (Diehl, Goertz, and Gallegos 2021; Thompson, Sakuwa, and Suhas 2022). As Halperin and Pliskin (2015) argue, persistent security tensions can permeate everyday life, structure public discourse, and shape the collective agenda. Statements such as the assertion that a “Chinese naval blockade or military attack on Taiwan could constitute a survival-threatening situation for Japan,” surface against a backdrop of decades of accumulated bitterness and shape the domestic political agenda (Hetherington 2026; Ninivaggi 2025; BBC 2014). Even ostensibly conciliatory exchanges are filtered through this adversarial lens: a meeting between the leaders of Greece and Turkey aimed at easing tensions, for instance, was nonetheless framed in the news media as “A war threat and a chance: Turkey and Greece face hard decisions—Any compromise would carry significant political costs at home, prompting caution on both sides” (Euractiv 2026). The narratives revolving

around the tension between nations routinely remind citizens of the hostile nature of the relationship, reinforcing the very rivalry they describe.

The persistence of rivalry is accompanied by a striking descriptive pattern in women’s political representation. Figure 1 plots the average share of women in parliament among countries engaged in interstate rivalries against the global average. Women’s representation has increased substantially in both groups over the past four decades, but rivalry states have consistently lagged behind the global trajectory. The gap is visible throughout the period and persists even as women have made considerable gains in political representation worldwide.

Figure 1: Women’s Representation in Rivalry States and the Global Average, 1975–2020



Note: The figure shows the average percentage of women in parliament among states engaged in an interstate rivalry and the global average by year. The shaded area represents the 95% confidence interval around the rivalry-state average.

This gap raises the question of how rivalry extends beyond interstate relations to restructure domestic political institutions and social norms. While not all rivalries produce conscription (e.g., the United States, Japan, India), states engaged in rivalries are generally more likely to adopt mandatory military service (Asal, Conrad, and Toronto 2017). Norms surrounding military preparedness diffuse from conscripts to the broader citizenry (Kim and Kang 2022), and the prominence of national security on the political agenda leads individuals to adopt worldviews shaped by persistent insecurity (Bar-Tal and Halperin 2013). Existing studies show that rivalry shapes a

wide range of domestic outcomes, from citizens' attitudes toward adversary populations to leadership turnover and domestic cohesion (Bak, Chávez, and Rider 2020; Gibler and Miller 2014; Han and Thies 2019; Kim, Kim, and Kwak 2024; Mari et al. 2022; Wimmer et al. 2024).

How Rivalry Undermines Women's Representation

I argue that rivalry constitutes a distinctive security environment that undermines women's representation, not by producing discrete moments of alarm, but by cultivating a long-term political culture that prepares citizens for militarized escalation while channeling confidence toward male leadership. Prolonged normalization of insecurity produces a political culture in which not only the armed forces, but citizens more broadly, are expected to remain prepared for mobilization even in the absence of immediate threat. I conceptualize the set of values that emerge from this condition as *reservist values*, which reflect the *diffusion of military values into civilian society*. Through education, media coverage, and mandatory military service (Asal, Conrad, and Toronto 2017; Lin et al. 2009; Yang and Liu 2012; Zheng, Du, and Xu 2025), sustained rivalry shapes citizens' attitudes in ways that closely parallel the logic of reserve forces, who must remain ready for mobilization at all times. This persistent state of preparedness places greater emphasis on hierarchy and reinforces men's dominance in positions of authority (Teele, Kalla, and Rosenbluth 2018; Schein 2007) and defines citizenship with values that have historically been framed as masculine, such as sacrifice, service, and protection (Best, Hunter, and Thomas 2021; Enloe 2013; Huntington 1981). As such, reservist values channel confidence toward existing power structures and their predominantly male occupants (Accorsi and Krebs 2025; Cheryan and Markus 2020; Mueller 1985), making citizens more skeptical of women's leadership.

To understand reservist values, it is first necessary to examine the defining characteristics of reserve forces. Reserve forces differ from active-duty personnel in their relationship to civilian life. While active-duty members serve continuously under military command, reservists maintain civilian jobs or studies while participating in periodic training and remaining available for mobilization during national emergencies. Their defining feature is this constant readiness for

full-time service, which places them at the intersection of military and civilian spheres and creates a broader societal link to national defense (Lomsky-Feder, Gazit, and Ben-Ari 2008). Because reservists must be prepared to fight when called upon, they internalize a militarized socialization characterized by deference to hierarchical authority, willingness to defend the nation in emergencies, and trust in institutions that issue orders, such as the military and the government more broadly (Huntington 1981; Soeters 2018). This belief system aligns closely with the social dynamics of geopolitical rivalry, which institutionalizes a sustained condition of vigilance.

Rivalries inherently carry the potential for militarized escalation that prompts states to entrench military preparedness (Diehl, Goertz, and Gallegos 2021; Thompson, Sakuwa, and Suhas 2022). Individuals living in rivalry environments likewise internalize the possibility of armed confrontation through repeated exposure to narratives of national security and persistent external threats. Rivalry states communicate these messages through education systems, media, political rhetoric, and military institutions, creating a “common sense” understanding of national threat that becomes embedded in everyday conceptions of politics and society (Lin et al. 2009; Yang and Liu 2012; Zheng, Du, and Xu 2025). This militarized socialization, in turn, exposes the broader citizenry to norms and expectations surrounding military preparedness (Kim and Kang 2022). Sustained geopolitical tension thus normalizes expectations of mobilization and devotion to the state, encouraging citizens to view participation in national defense as a civic obligation, “even to the extent of willingness to sacrifice their lives for the state” (Bar-Tal et al. 2012, p. 41).

This pressure for state preparedness and the need for public compliance generate a distinctive political culture—a set of durable background orientations toward society and the political system that shape citizens’ political attitudes (Almond and Verba 1963). When reservist values become the dominant political culture in rivalry states, leadership evaluation is filtered through its three constituent pillars, conformity to hierarchical authority, emphasis on national defense duty, and trust in military institutions, and women are systematically disadvantaged under each. The following section explains why these manifestations are especially salient under conditions of interstate rivalry and how they undermine confidence in women’s leadership.

Conformity to hierarchical authority

Rivalry states value adherence to hierarchical authority. Acceptance of hierarchical authority facilitates collective action by setting clear responsibilities along chains of command, which reduces uncertainty about who should act, when, and how (Anicich, Swaab, and Galinsky 2015). Such hierarchy is particularly helpful in environments that demand rapid interpretation of signals and swift execution of decisions, such as conflict settings. Conformity to authority further strengthens intragroup coordination by limiting internal contestation. Compliance becomes more predictable when lower status members are less inclined to challenge superiors, and this allows leaders to mobilize resources and implement directives with fewer delays (Anicich, Swaab, and Galinsky 2015). Because rivalry requires continuous vigilance for potential crises, hierarchical authority becomes routinized in everyday interactions in order to sustain coordination and reduce the risk of fragmentation.

When hierarchical authority is highly valued, women are disadvantaged with respect to both formal institutional recognition and also their capacity to shape others' attitudes and behavior. With respect to formal authority, men's prevalence across politics, business, and other public domains normalizes their exercise of power and shapes expectations about who legitimately holds authority (Teele, Kalla, and Rosenbluth 2018; Schein 2007; Wängnerud 2009). This visibility reinforces a masculine default in which traits associated with men define competent leadership, rendering women's presence in comparable roles as incongruent with prevailing norms (Cheryan and Markus 2020; Eagly and Karau 2002; Heilman, Caleo, and Manzi 2024). As men become the status quo of legitimate authority, women's presence in comparable leadership roles appears incongruent with prevailing norms (Heilman, Caleo, and Manzi 2024). Yet even when women occupy formal leadership positions, they do not necessarily possess the capacity to shape others' judgments or guide collective decision-making (Caverley and Krupnikov 2024). Their contributions in deliberative settings are more frequently interrupted even in highly institutionalized bodies, which reduces their influence relative to male counterparts with equivalent formal standing (Miller and Sutherland 2023). As a result, the authority that formal positions nominally confer

is unevenly realized in practice, as men's formal roles translate more readily into perceived influence, while women must continually overcome credibility deficits that their positions alone do not resolve. When authority is especially prized, as it is under rivalry, these patterns of exclusion and bias become more pronounced.

Civic duty towards national defense

Rivalry states have strong incentives to cultivate civic duty oriented toward national defense. Internally-driven compliance reduces the administrative burden of enforcement, which allows the state to implement security policies through routine governance rather than coercion (Deth 2017). More importantly, voluntary willingness to defend the country is essential when manpower is most needed, as formal obligations alone do not guarantee participation under wartime pressure. Reports of desertion and Absent Without Leave (AWOL) in both Ukraine and Russia illustrate how noncompliance can produce severe infantry shortages even under legal penalty (Asami 2026; Ponomareva 2025). Rivalry states therefore have incentives to foster not merely rule-following, but an internalized commitment to collective defense that normalizes sacrifice and service as expressions of national belonging rather than state imposition.

Such emphasis on civic duty of national defense represents one of the most powerful channels through which rivalries can reinforce gendered hierarchies of political leadership. The meaning of citizenship in militarized social environments becomes closely intertwined with sacrifice, service, and protection, all of which are values that have historically been framed as masculine (Best, Hunter, and Thomas 2021; Enloe 2013; Huntington 1981). The act of defending the nation, among others, is often seen as the highest expression of civic virtue (Gross 2008; Lashof 1996; Nesbit and Reingold 2011). This association creates an implicit hierarchy of citizenship, where men, who are expected to serve and sacrifice, are viewed as more legitimate political actors than women (Cohen, Huff, and Schub 2021; Enloe 2014). Women, in contrast, are often positioned as dependents to the state rather than as its protectors, which diminishes perceptions of their suitability for leadership

roles (Kwon 2000).¹

Empirical evidence from highly militarized societies illustrates this pattern. In contexts such as South Korea, where conscription institutionalizes male military service as a civic obligation, men often view their service as conferring a form of moral entitlement (Kwon 2000). Studies show that this perception contributes to resentment toward gender-based policies, including quotas and skepticism about women's political competence (Bae and Lee 2024). The broader implication is that rivalry environments, by elevating sacrifice and protection as the markers of full citizenship, intensify the gender gap in political legitimacy (Huntington 1981; Persson and Sundevall 2019). In these settings, civic virtue becomes masculinized and leadership becomes synonymous with the capacity to defend rather than to deliberate, undermining the normative space for women's authority (Enloe 2014).

Trust in military institution

The last pillar of reservist values is trust in military institution, whose directives citizens must be willing to follow in times of emergency. More broadly, institutional trust facilitates compliance with state demands, including conscription, taxation, and restrictions on individual freedom during crises (Orviska and Hudson 2003; Caplanova, Sivak, and Szakadatova 2021). Under conditions of interstate rivalry, however, trust in the military is particularly consequential, as security preparedness places distinctive demands on citizens. Trust in the military increases citizens' willingness to volunteer for service, accept conscription, and support military spending (Accorsi and Krebs 2025). In crisis situations where the military assumes broad authority over civilian life, trust in military institution becomes the foundation upon which compliance rests. Rivalry states therefore have incentives to cultivate trust in military institutions as a background condition of social order, ensuring that citizens remain willing to support and comply with the institutions responsible for national defense.

¹Even when women are drawn into national defense, their participation is often justified through exceptionalist narratives of patriotic necessity and does not necessarily transform gendered citizenship. For instance, Santana (2016) shows that while the Rosie the Riveter narrative contributed to women's wartime empowerment, postwar expectations pushed many women back toward domestic roles.

Trust in military institutions yet serves as another pathway through which rivalry reinforces gender bias in political leadership. Rivalries often sustain a militarized political culture in which the armed forces are central to national identity and social order (Kim 2019). When the military is among the most trusted institutions in society, its values of discipline, hierarchy, obedience, and strength become the normative template for leadership itself (Enloe 2013; Goldstein 2003; Kwon 2000). These values privilege traditionally masculine traits and marginalize qualities more commonly associated with collaborative or inclusive leadership styles, reinforcing both male authority and military values more broadly. Consequently, women's leadership becomes less conceivable within the moral framework of governance (Holman, Merolla, and Zechmeister 2011; Lawless 2004).

In summary, deference to hierarchical authority, civic duty oriented toward national defense, and trust in military institutions constitute a political culture grounded in reservist values that rivalry both requires and sustains. Enduring geopolitical hostility demands hierarchical compliance to enable coordinated mobilization, civic duty to sustain willingness to sacrifice, and institutional trust to secure the legitimacy of collective action. These same conditions, however, undermine the recognition of women's leadership by normalizing vertical authority structures that exclude women, elevating masculine-coded notions of civic virtue, and reinforcing confidence in male dominated institutions. The result is a political culture that supports preparedness for mobilization while constraining women's political representation.²

Study 1: Reservist values and Support for Women Leaders

So far, I have theorized that the constant need for preparedness in rivalries cultivates reservist values among citizens, and that these reservist values reduce support for women as political leaders. In this section, I turn to the data to evaluate both claims.

²reservist values bear a family resemblance to what scholars have called militarism (Kim and Kang 2022; Kwon 2000; Stavrianakis and Selby 2012). Appendix E provides a detailed discussion of how reservist values relate to the broader literature on militarism and extends existing conceptualizations.

Empirical strategy

To this end, I draw on individual-level data from the Integrated Values Survey (IVS), a cross-national longitudinal survey that integrates the European Values Study and the World Values Survey. The data consist of seven waves spanning from 1981 to 2021 with nationally representative samples. Following the analytical strategy employed by Kim and Kang (2022) to examine the effects of external threat on support for women's leadership, I estimate hierarchical linear models with individuals nested within countries and survey years to account for the non-independence of observations arising from the clustered data structure. Random intercepts are included for country and year to account for unobserved heterogeneity across national and temporal contexts. Appendix [F.1](#) lists the countries included in the analyses.

The rivalry status draws on the Peace Data by Diehl, Goertz, and Gallegos (2021), which provides historical and contemporary information on dyadic rivalries. Based on a holistic evaluation of war plans, conflicts, interstate communication, diplomatic exchanges, and mutual negotiations and agreements, the dataset constructs a peace scale ranging from 0 (severe rivalry) to 1 (security community). I code a country-year as experiencing rivalry when its peace score equals 0, indicating the presence of severe and persistent rivalry with at least one other state.³ This binary indicator serves as the main explanatory variable. Importantly, severe rivalry does not necessarily involve ongoing or repeated armed conflict, as it mainly captures an enduring antagonistic relationship in which states view one another as enemies and structure their foreign policy accordingly (e.g., the United States–Soviet Union during the Cold War or the contemporary China–Taiwan relationship). Appendix [A](#) provides a detailed discussion of how severe rivalry is conceptualized, the components that inform its measurement, and the conditions under which countries transition to lesser levels of rivalry.

The outcome variables are measures of conformity to hierarchical authority, civic duty toward national defense, and trust in military institutions. I measure conformity to hierarchical author-

³This study restricts attention to high intensity rivalries by coding the rivalry indicator as 1 only when the peace scale equals 0. Accordingly, the results should be interpreted as assessing whether prolonged exposure to high intensity rivalry is associated with different patterns of women's representation.

ity using respondents' attitudes toward respect for authority. Respondents were asked whether greater respect for authority would be desirable as a future social change, with response options ranging from (1) good thing to (3) bad thing. The item is reverse-coded so that higher values on *Respect Authority* indicate a more favorable view of greater respect for authority. To measure civic duty toward national defense, I use a question asking respondents whether they would be willing to fight for their country, coded as *Willingness to Fight* (1 = yes, 0 = no). To capture trust in military institutions, I use a survey item asking how much confidence respondents have in the armed forces. Responses range from (1) a great deal to (4) not at all and are reverse-coded so that higher values on *Trust Army* indicate greater confidence in these institutions.

To assess whether the association between rivalry, reservist values, and support for women's leadership persists net of broader socioeconomic conditions, all models control for the occurrence of terrorism events and militarized interstate disputes within the previous three years, logged military spending as a share of GDP, level of democracy, NATO membership, EU membership, the presence of mixed electoral system, the proportion of women in parliament, and the ideological orientation of the executive. The models also control for economic conditions and institutional policies, such as logged GDP per capita and the presence of gender quotas. The individual-level controls include age, gender, political ideology, income, religion, and religiosity. Standard errors are estimated from mixed-effects models with crossed country and year random intercepts. Degrees of freedom for fixed-effect tests are approximated using Satterthwaite's method, which provides small-sample-corrected inference.

Results

I first examine whether citizens in rivalry states demonstrate heightened reservist values compared to those in non-rivalry states. As shown in Table 1, citizens in rivalry states demonstrate stronger respect for authority ($p = 0.017$), heightened willingness to fight for country ($p < 0.001$), and greater trust in the armed forces ($p = 0.012$). Consistent with the theory, rivalry is associated with stronger reservist values, orienting citizens toward collective prepared-

ness and confidence in military institutions. Appendix Table F.3 shows that the same pattern does not hold for acute security shocks. Terrorism raises willingness to fight — consistent with a rally 'round the flag effect — but lowers respect for authority and military trust. MIDs, by contrast, erode institutional confidence and dampen willingness to bear the costs of defense. Rivalry, unlike these acute shocks, moves all three pillars of reservist values in tandem.

Table 1: Reservist Attitudes in Rivalries

	Respect Authority	Willing Fight	Trust Army
Rivalry	0.047* (0.020)	0.061*** (0.014)	0.064* (0.025)
Num.Obs.	137 520	123 549	137 919
Num.Ctry	47	46	47
Controls	✓	✓	✓

Signif. Codes: * $p < 0.05$; ** $p < 0.01$; *** $p < 0.001$,

Note: This table reports coefficients from hierarchical linear models with random intercepts for country and year. Degrees of freedom for fixed-effect tests are approximated using Satterthwaite's method and p-values are adjusted using the Benjamini–Hochberg procedure. Full covariate estimates are reported in Appendix Table F.3.

I next examine whether each of the three pillars of reservist values predicts lower support for women's political representation. I use a survey item commonly used in the literature, which asks respondents whether they agree with the statement "Men make better political leaders than women do." Responses range from (1) agree strongly to (4) disagree strongly. In line with Kim and Kang (2022), I reverse-code this item so that higher values indicate greater support for women's leadership and then recode it into a binary variable, where 1 denotes support for women's leadership and 0 denotes lack of support.

Table 2: Reservist Values and Bias Against Women's Leadership

	(1)	(2)	(3)
Respect Authority	−0.024*** (0.002)		
Willing Fight		−0.007* (0.003)	
Trust Army			−0.019*** (0.002)
Num.Obs.	123 073	110 975	123 343
Num.Ctry	47	46	47
Controls	✓	✓	✓

Signif. Codes: * $p < 0.05$; ** $p < 0.01$; *** $p < 0.001$

Note: This table reports coefficients from hierarchical linear models with random intercepts for country and year. Each column corresponds to a separate model using support for women's leadership as the dependent variable, and each row reports the estimated coefficients for the key independent variables. Degrees of freedom for fixed-effect tests are approximated using Satterthwaite's method. Full covariate estimates are reported in Appendix Table F.4.

Table 2 shows that all three attitudinal dimensions, respect for authority ($p < 0.001$), willingness to fight ($p = 0.025$), and trust in the military ($p < 0.001$) are significantly and negatively associated with support for women's political leadership. These results support the theory that reservist values channel confidence toward existing power structures and their predominantly male occupants, making those who hold such beliefs more skeptical of women's leadership. Taken together, the results from this section yield two conclusions: first, that citizens in rivalry states exhibit stronger reservist values; second, that reservist values predict lower support for women's political leadership. If these two findings are connected in the way the theory suggests, we would expect (i) citizens in rivalry states to be less supportive of women in political leadership and, insofar as these attitudes shape electoral behavior, (ii) rivalry states to exhibit lower levels of women's political representation. The following section demonstrates that the empirical evidence is consistent with both expectations.

Study 2: Women’s Underrepresentation in Rivalry

Table 3: Bias Against Women’s Leadership

Support for Women as Political Leaders	
Rivalry	−0.045** (0.014)
Num.Obs.	125 417
Num.Ctry	47
Controls	✓

Signif. Codes: * $p < 0.05$; ** $p < 0.01$; *** $p < 0.001$,

Note: This table reports coefficients from hierarchical linear models with random intercepts for country and year. Standard errors are adjusted for hierarchical structure using Satterthwaite’s approximation. Full covariate estimates are reported in Appendix Table F.1.

Using the previous IVS items, I first examine whether citizens in rivalry states express lower levels of support for women’s political leadership. The independent variable is the binary indicator of rivalry status, and the dependent variable comes from the survey item “Men make better political leaders than women do.” As shown in Table 3, citizens in rivalry states report 4.5 percentage points lower support for women’s leadership compared to those in non-rivalry states ($p = 0.001$). This result confirms that citizens in rivalry states, who report heightened reservist values, also demonstrate greater bias against women’s leadership.

I next turn to whether this voter-level bias translates into electoral outcomes. To evaluate whether rivalry is associated with lower levels of women’s political representation, I analyze data from 83 democracies between 1975 and 2020.⁴ The dataset consists of 11 states engaged in interstate rivalries until the end of the study period, including Colombia, Cyprus, Greece, India, Israel, Japan, South Korea, Turkey, Taiwan, and the United States; 22 states that transitioned from a period of severe rivalry to more peaceful relations during the study period, including

⁴Not all countries in the sample are democratic throughout the entire study period. Several cases experienced episodes of authoritarian rule or democratic backsliding, and levels of democratic consolidation vary across countries. To address this variation, democracy is operationalized using the average V-Dem democracy score over the post-Cold War period, and countries are classified as democratic if this average exceeds 0.5. The results hold when applying a stricter democracy threshold of 0.7, as shown in Table B.3.

Argentina, Germany, France, the United Kingdom, and South Africa; and 50 states, including Australia, Belgium, Brazil, Mexico, the Netherlands, and Portugal, that did not experience rivalry between 1975 and 2020. The full list of countries included in each group is provided in Appendix B.1. The dependent variable is the percentage (%) of seats held by women in national parliaments, which captures the level of women’s electoral representation in a given country-year. The model includes the same set of country-level controls as in the IVS analysis.

I begin with descriptive evidence. Appendix Table B.2 reports results from cross-sectional OLS models that pool each country’s observations across the study period. A bivariate estimate shows that countries engaged in interstate rivalry throughout the study period have, on average, a 6.1 percentage point lower share of women in parliament ($p = 0.003$). This association remains negative and statistically significant as controls are added sequentially, with the fully controlled model showing an 8.9 percentage point lower share of women in parliament ($p = 0.002$). The results hold across a wide range of alternative specifications. Applying a stricter democracy threshold (average V-Dem score of 0.7; Table B.3), excluding Israel (the case with the most regional rivalries; Table B.4), and excluding the United States (the only great power rivalry case and the only case without geographically proximate rivals; Table B.5) do not alter the direction or significance of the key coefficients. Extending controls for militarized interstate disputes and terrorism from three to ten years (Table B.6) or restricting the sample to countries without conflict episodes in the past ten years (Table B.7) likewise leaves the results unchanged, suggesting that the effect of rivalry is distinct from the legacy of war, and the findings are not driven by rivalry states with recurrent conflicts.

It is nevertheless possible that unobserved differences between countries that experience rivalry and those that never do, and even between persistent rivalries and those that later terminate, can confound cross-country comparisons. To address this concern, I estimate a two-way fixed effects (TWFE) model that relies exclusively on within-country variation in rivalry status over time. The key independent variable is the one-year lagged rivalry status, and the dependent variable is the proportion of women in parliament. The model includes the same set of covariates as

the cross-sectional specification and standard errors are clustered at the country level to account for serial correlation. The unit of analysis is country-year.

The dataset includes 23 countries that experienced a change in rivalry status between 1975 and 2020, with individual rivalry episodes lasting from 4 to 38 years (mean = 15.7, median = 14).⁵ Because short-lived rivalries are unlikely to produce the institutional and societal transformations through which sustained rivalry influences women's political representation, including these brief episodes could attenuate the estimated effect of long-term rivalry. As such, I first estimate models using the full set of countries that underwent a change in rivalry status, and then re-estimate them after sequentially excluding cases with fewer than five rivalry years (Spain) and those with fewer than ten rivalry years (Bosnia and Herzegovina, Canada, Chile, Germany, the Dominican Republic, Spain, Croatia, and Hungary).⁶

Table 4 presents the estimates from TWFE models. In the full sample, rivalry is associated with a 1.54 percentage point lower share of women in parliament. Although this estimate does not reach conventional levels of statistical significance ($p = 0.186$), the association increases in magnitude and is estimated with greater precision when countries with only brief rivalry histories are excluded. Excluding cases with fewer than five years of rivalry yields a 2.54 percentage point decrease ($p = 0.015$), and excluding those with fewer than ten years produces a 3.74 percentage point decrease ($p = 0.007$).⁷ Taken together, the cross-sectional and longitudinal panel analyses provide consistent evidence that protracted rivalries undermine women's representation. The findings from Study 2 thus suggest not only that citizens in rivalry states exhibit greater bias against women as political leaders, but also that this bias is reflected in lower levels of women's legislative representation.

⁵Appendix A provides a detailed discussion of the conceptualization of rivalry and the processes through which states transition into and out of severe rivalry.

⁶Because military expenditure data are unavailable for Costa Rica across the study period, the fully specified TWFE models exclude Costa Rica through complete-case deletion. As a robustness check, Appendix Table C.3 re-estimates the TWFE models without the military spending control, thereby retaining Costa Rica in the estimating sample. The main results remain robust in this alternative specification.

⁷Table C.4 reports results from models that include only country and year fixed effects, without additional time-varying covariates. The results remain robust to this alternative specification.

Table 4: Within-Country TWFE Estimates

	All rivalry episodes	Rivalries lasting 5+ years	Rivalries lasting 10+ years
Rivalry	−1.537 (1.124)	−2.538* (0.953)	−3.736** (1.179)
Num.Obs.	746	703	483
R2	0.831	0.835	0.848

Signif. Codes: * $p < 0.05$; ** $p < 0.01$; *** $p < 0.001$

Note: The table reports estimates from two-way fixed effects models in which the dependent variable is the proportion of women in parliament and the key explanatory variable is rivalry status lagged by one year. Full covariate estimates are reported in Appendix Table C.1. Country-clustered standard errors are reported in parentheses.

Study 3: Reservist Values Scale

Yet several important questions remain. Do reservist values cohere as a single construct? Are they simply another manifestation of existing concepts, such as conservatism, militarism, or right-wing authoritarianism? What, if anything, does this construct capture that existing measures do not? The IVS alone cannot adjudicate this, as it includes one item per pillar and lacks the batteries needed to control for these competing constructs. To answer these questions, I conducted a series of original surveys across five democracies. The goal of these surveys is to develop and validate a measure of reservist values and to determine whether it predicts skepticism toward women in politics above and beyond existing attitudinal measures.

Study design

The main analysis draws on a four-country survey fielded in South Korea, Taiwan, Finland, and Denmark.⁸ I use this survey both to develop the reservist values scale and to evaluate its predictive validity. To assess whether the measurement structure replicates beyond these cases, I use two

⁸The reservist values scale is embedded within a multi-country survey experiment. The scale items are presented to all participants prior to treatment assignment and are therefore not contaminated by any experimental manipulation. For the scale development analysis, all respondents are included regardless of experimental condition, as the analysis relies solely on the pre-treatment reservist values measure. All correlation analyses are restricted to respondents assigned to the control condition of the experiment.

additional surveys fielded in the United States and South Korea. Across the main four-country survey, approximately 600 respondents were recruited online in each country, yielding a total sample of 2,489 respondents. Respondents in each country were nationally representative in terms of age, gender, and region. Appendix Table H.1 presents detailed summary statistics of the sample used in the analysis.

Table 5: Reservist Belief Scale Items

Item	Wording
<i>Hierarchical Authority</i>	
A1	In any society, some people must make decisions, and others need to follow them.
A2	In work settings, I prefer a clear chain of command rather than a fully horizontal decision-making structure.
A3	Even when students disagree with a teacher, they should follow the teacher's instructions.
A4*	In no cases is it justified for parents to use physical discipline to correct their children.
<i>Civic Duty</i>	
C1	If a war were to occur, I would be willing to fight for my country.
C2	I would feel a responsibility to contribute to national defense even if I were not legally required to do so.
C3	People who refuse to serve in the military during wartime are acting selfishly.
C4*	Citizens do not have a duty to defend the country, even when it is under serious threat.
<i>Institutional Trust</i>	
T1	I generally trust the government.
T2	I generally trust the military.
T3*	The government can rarely be trusted to do what is right.
T4*	The army can rarely be trusted to do what is right.

* Reverse-coded items. All items measured on a six-point scale ranging from 1 (Strongly disagree) to 6 (Strongly agree).

A set of candidate items was developed to measure reservist values across three theoretically motivated domains. The battery includes four items capturing conformity to hierarchical authority, four items capturing civic duty centered on willingness to fight for the country, and four items capturing trust in government and the military.⁹ Table 5 displays the full wording for each item. Response options range from 1 (strongly disagree) to 6 (strongly agree), and all items are

⁹The initial candidate battery for the third pillar included items measuring trust in government as well as trust in the military, in order to assess whether reservist values reflect trust in military institutions specifically or broader confidence in centralized state institutions more generally.

rescaled to 0-1 prior to analysis.

Scale construction and validation

To assess the factor structure of the reservist values scale, I conducted an exploratory factor analysis (EFA) on a randomly selected half of the sample, examining whether the twelve candidate items clustered along the three theorized dimensions. In this initial stage, three items failed to perform as expected. The authority item A4, which asked whether parents are ever justified in using physical discipline, loaded on a separate factor rather than on the hierarchical authority dimension. The civic duty item C4, which denies that citizens have a duty to defend the country, exhibited substantial cross loadings across multiple factors. Among the trust items, the estimated loading of T1 ("I generally trust the government") produced a Heywood case, with an estimated loading exceeding 1. These three items were removed following the initial EFA.

The retained nine items were then submitted to a confirmatory factor analysis (CFA) on a held-out half of the sample. In these specifications, the remaining government trust item (T3), which states that the government can rarely be trusted, failed to load cleanly on the institutional trust factor. This rules out the possibility that the trust pillar of reservist values reflects generalized institutional confidence, indicating instead that, at the individual level, it is anchored specifically in trust toward the military. After removing this item, the final measurement model consists of eight items: three hierarchical authority items (A1-A3), three civic duty items (C1-C3), and two items measuring trust in the military (T2 and T4). Appendix Figure [H.1](#) illustrates the mean and median values for each item.

A second-order confirmatory factor analysis of this final specification indicates that hierarchical authority, civic duty, and military trust load onto a common latent construct of reservist values. The model exhibits good fit (Robust CFI = 0.977, Robust TLI = 0.964, Robust RMSEA = 0.049 [90% CI: 0.034–0.064], SRMR = 0.031), supporting the interpretation of reservist values as a higher-order construct composed of three dimensions. All second-order loadings were positive and statistically significant. Civic duty ($\beta = 0.776$) loaded most strongly onto the reservist

values factor, followed by military trust ($\beta = 0.703$) and hierarchical authority ($\beta = 0.692$), with all three dimensions contributing significantly to the broader construct. Detailed results are reported in Appendix Table H.2.

To assess whether the three-factor hierarchical structure of reservist values replicates, I conducted a confirmatory factor analysis on survey data collected separately in the United States ($N = 250$). This time, items A2 and A3 were slightly modified to reflect general societal norms rather than the specific settings of the workplace (A2) or school (A3). A2 was worded as “In general, I prefer a clear chain of command rather than a fully horizontal decision-making structure,” and A3 was worded as “Even when people disagree with authority figures, they should follow the instructions of legitimate authorities.” As in the earlier analyses, the model specified three first-order factors—hierarchical authority, civic duty, and military trust—that loaded onto a common second-order reservist values factor (Appendix Table H.3). All first- and second-order loadings were positive and statistically significant, with the three dimensions contributing substantially to the higher-order construct ($\beta = 0.574\text{--}0.842$). Internal consistency across all eight items was strong (Cronbach’s $\alpha = 0.85$).

The final scale replication was held in South Korea ($N = 1,999$). Given the similarity in wording between the two military trust items, the second item (T4) was slightly reworded to reduce item redundancy (“In times of national crisis, the military can be trusted to act in the country’s best interest.”). As before, the model specified three first-order factors loading onto a single second-order reservist values factor (Appendix Table H.4). All first-order loadings were positive and statistically significant ($p < 0.001$; standardized loadings ranged 0.463–0.848 across items), and all three subdimensions loaded strongly and significantly onto the second-order factor ($\beta = 0.747\text{--}0.799$). Model fit was strong across every index (Robust CFI = 0.986, Robust TLI = 0.977, Robust RMSEA = 0.043 [90% CI: 0.031–0.054], SRMR = 0.023) and internal consistency across all eight items remained strong (Cronbach’s $\alpha = 0.80$).

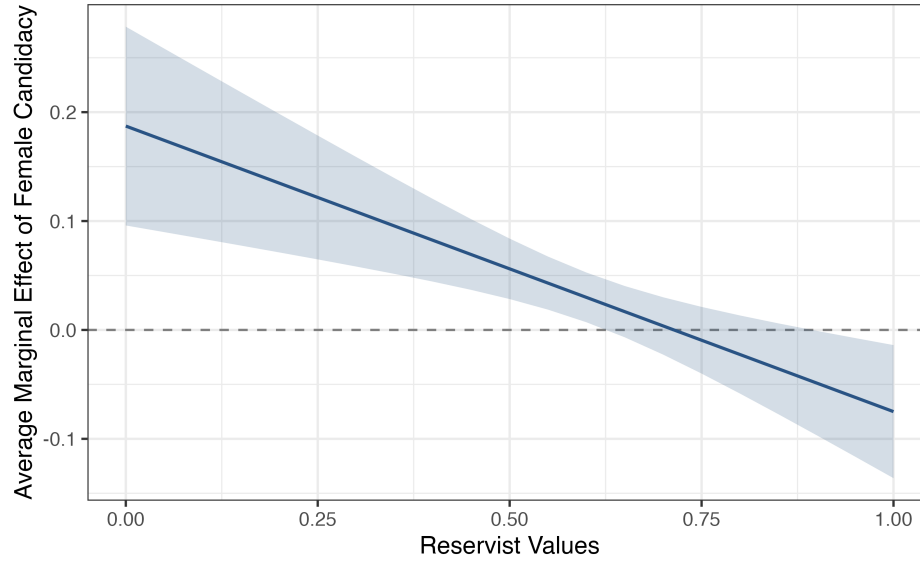
Scale predictive validity

Having established the measurement structure of reservist values and shown that it replicates in two additional surveys, I test whether reservist values directly predicts support for women in political leadership using a forced-choice conjoint experiment. Respondents were asked to choose between two hypothetical candidates whose age, gender, political experience, professional experience, and political ideology were randomly assigned.¹⁰ The analysis estimates the average marginal component effect (AMCE) of candidate gender on the probability that a candidate profile is selected. To assess whether reservist belief shapes evaluations of candidate gender, I focus on the interaction between the female candidate attribute and respondents' level of reservist values.

A common concern is that reservist values may proxy for broader militaristic, traditional, or authoritarian predispositions. To address this, I estimate a model that includes separate interactions between candidate gender and each of the following respondent-level predispositions: reservist values, militarism, right-wing authoritarianism, conservative ideology, hostile sexism, and benevolent sexism. This allows the model to partial out the portion of the reservist values effect that operates through these correlated attitudes, providing a conservative test of whether reservist values independently shapes candidate preferences. The model additionally controls for candidate attributes and respondents' sociodemographic characteristics including age, gender, education, income, nationality, religiosity, and prior military service.

¹⁰The order of attributes was randomized across respondents but held constant within each respondent throughout the six choice tasks to minimize bias arising from attribute position.

Figure 2: Reservist Values and Female Candidate Preference



Note: The figure displays the average marginal effect (AME) of candidate gender (women vs. men) on selection probability across the distribution of reservist values. Shaded area represents 95% confidence intervals. Estimates are from a linear probability model with standard errors clustered by respondent.

The result in Figure 2 supports the expectation. Among respondents with the lowest observed levels of reservist values, women candidates are selected at significantly higher rates than men (AME = 0.185, 95% CI [0.094, 0.277], $p < 0.001$). This advantage declines steadily and loses statistical significance around the midpoint of the reservist values distribution, consistent with the negative and significant interaction between female candidacy and reservist values ($\beta = -0.259$, $p < 0.001$). At the upper end of the distribution, the effect reverses: respondents holding the highest reservist values significantly prefer male candidates (AME = -0.074 , 95% CI [-0.135 , -0.013], $p = 0.018$). These results hold after controlling for candidate attributes, militarism, conservative ideology, and sexism, suggesting that reservist values shape electoral preferences for women candidates above and beyond conventional predictors of gender bias in politics.

The evidence presented thus far demonstrates that rivalry undermines women's representation by cultivating reservist values, which prepare citizens for militarized escalation while channeling confidence toward male leadership. In an ideal world, states would resolve their rivalries and transition toward more peaceful interstate relations, removing the conditions that sustain

these gendered consequences. Yet ending rivalry itself is exceedingly difficult. Can bias against women's leadership be reduced even in states that remain locked in protracted rivalry? I take up this question in the final section.

Study 4: Strategies to Mitigate Bias Against Women's Leadership

Several considerations motivate the intervention strategies. If reservist values are instilled through long-term processes of socialization via education, media, and military institutions, they are unlikely to be easily unlearned. Moreover, reservist values may serve an important function in a protracted rivalry context, given that they help prepare citizens for potential militarized escalation. Removing them outright may not be desirable, even if it were possible. Given these conditions, the final section tests two strategies that work within the existing value structure: *retribution* and *substitution*. Retribution preserves the importance of reservist values while associating them with women, whereas substitution broadens the criteria used to evaluate political leadership by emphasizing an alternative set of civic values recognized as valuable to the state: non-hierarchical decision making, civic freedom, and scrutiny in the military.

These strategies reflect long-standing approaches to demonstrating women's suitability for traditionally male-dominated roles. In response to resistance to women's greater representation in political spaces (Mansell et al. 2022; Okimoto and Brescoll 2010), scholars and activists have pursued two broad strategies. The first seeks to counter the belief that women lack the qualities necessary for effective leadership by demonstrating that they are equally capable of meeting existing standards of power and competence (Eagly et al. 2019). Advocates, for instance, highlight women's military service and combat roles, depict women as charismatic leaders, and emphasize women's hawkish positions on national security (Alison 2004; Bendix and Jeong 2020). These efforts focus on proving that women are just as capable as men of embodying the qualities associated with effective leadership.

The reattribution treatment builds on this approach by preserving the positive framing of reservist values while expanding who is perceived as embodying them. It begins by emphasizing the societal benefits of reservist values, reflecting the way these values are positively reinforced through socialization, political discourse, and media narratives in countries engaged in protracted geopolitical rivalries (Asal, Conrad, and Toronto 2017; Lin et al. 2009; Yang and Liu 2012; Zheng, Du, and Xu 2025). At the same time, it highlights that women increasingly embody these same values through their growing roles in positions of authority and national service. The core idea behind reattribution is therefore to expand who is perceived as meeting the *existing* standards by which political leaders are evaluated. If reservist values are no longer viewed as attributes uniquely possessed by men, continued support for those values need not disadvantage women seeking political leadership.

The second strategy challenges the assumption that traditionally masculine-coded qualities should serve as the default standard for competence (Duncanson and Woodward 2016; Persson and Sundevall 2019). Instead of persuading that women can satisfy traditionally masculine expectations, it questions whether those expectations should define effective leadership in the first place. The rationale behind this approach is that, as Eagly and Karau (2002, p. 574) argue, “prejudice toward female leaders follows from the incongruity that many people perceive between the characteristics of women and the requirements of leader roles.” Accordingly, if leadership roles are defined in less masculine terms, prejudice against women leaders may weaken (Erikson and Josefsson 2023). For instance, emphasizing the importance of qualities that have traditionally received less recognition as indicators of effective leadership, such as empathy (Shogan 2009; Yorke 2023), may reduce bias against women leaders by making leadership roles more congruent with women’s perceived strengths.

The substitution treatment is motivated by this second approach. Whereas the reattribution treatment preserves the importance of reservist values while arguing that women are equally capable of embodying them, the substitution treatment broadens the effective leadership criteria by presenting an *alternative* set of civic values that counterbalance the dimensions of reservist val-

ues: non-hierarchical decision-making (rather than hierarchical decision-making), civic freedom (rather than civic duty), and scrutiny of the military (rather than trust in the military). Emphasizing the importance of questioning authority, constraining concentrations of power, and creating space for voices outside existing hierarchies encourages respondents to place greater weight on accountability and independent judgment. To the extent that citizens adopt a broader conception of effective leadership that places greater value on independent judgment and institutional checks on authority, women's historical outsider status may become an asset rather than a liability, as it creates greater receptiveness to women as representatives of institutional reform and alternative approaches to governance (Armstrong et al. 2023; O'Brien 2015). I thus expect the two interventions to increase support for women's political representation.¹¹

Empirical strategy

To test these strategies, I field an original survey experiment in South Korea. South Korea has confronted a long-standing neighboring adversary, North Korea, for more than seventy years. The prolonged geopolitical rivalry makes South Korea an optimal setting for examining the political consequences of reservist values. At the same time, South Korea also provides a hard test of the theory. Despite recent gains in women's access to political office across democracies, women hold only 20.8% of seats in the South Korean National Assembly, placing the country 117th out of 181 countries and well below the OECD average of 34%. The experiment therefore evaluates whether reservist values shape support for women leaders in a political context where women remain substantially underrepresented in elected office, making it particularly difficult to shift evaluations of women political leaders through an experimental intervention.

¹¹It is possible that activating reservist values further diminishes support for women's political leadership. The experiment tests this possibility; the results are reported in the Appendix.

Table 6: Experimental Treatment Vignettes

Condition	Vignette Text
Reattribution	Research Shows that Strong Nations Start With Citizens Who Follow and Trust, and Women Excel in Providing Such Leadership Scholars have long debated which societal values best enable countries to protect themselves and thrive. A substantial body of research shows that respect for authority in everyday social interactions is essential. Fragmented command structures slow response times and leave societies vulnerable at precisely the moments that demand swift, unified action. A strong sense of civic duty is equally critical. Without it, societies struggle to count on citizens to align personal interests with collective obligations, making it hard to sustain the shared burdens that national defense inevitably requires. And trust in the military determines whether institutions can act with the speed and legitimacy needed to deter adversaries. States where that trust has eroded face paralysis, defection, and an inability to project credible resolve. Together, these values are considered essential for state stability and civic coordination. Importantly, scholars find that these values are increasingly demonstrated by women across public life, as women take on greater authority, contribute to national service, and play a growing role in building trust in military institutions.
Substitution	Research Shows that Strong Nations Start With Citizens Who Question and are Critical Scholars have long debated which societal values best enable countries to protect themselves and thrive. A substantial body of research shows that non-hierarchical decision-making in everyday social interactions is essential. Societies that suppress independent judgment become brittle, unable to adapt when rigid command structures produce strategic errors with catastrophic consequences. A strong sense of civic freedom is equally critical. Without it, citizens defend their country as an obligation rather than a conviction, producing fragile compliance rather than the durable commitment that sustained national effort requires. And scrutiny of the military is what prevents unchecked power from corroding institutions from within. States that silence accountability mechanisms often become their own worst enemy. Together, these values are considered essential for state stability and civic coordination.
Control	Research Shows that Strong Nations Start With Well-Maintained Infrastructure Scholars have long debated which public investments best enable a country's security and prosperity. A substantial body of research shows that regular road maintenance is essential. Keeping road surfaces in good condition reduces wear on vehicles, improves travel reliability, and helps transportation systems operate more efficiently over time. Maintaining safe drinking water systems is equally critical. Without it, aging pipes and treatment facilities can reduce water quality and increase the need for costly repairs. And routine inspection and maintenance of public infrastructure is what allows essential services to operate reliably. Regular upkeep helps extend the lifespan of infrastructure and reduces the likelihood of unexpected disruptions. Together, these practices are considered essential for public safety and national wellbeing.

Note: Bolded text reflects the bolding shown to respondents in the experimental stimuli. The first bolded line in each vignette is the title presented to respondents; subsequent bolded phrases appear in bold within the body of the vignette text.

Following the attention check, respondents are randomly assigned to one of the experimental arms. Table 6 presents the full text of the experimental vignettes. After reading the text, respondents are presented with an image that summarizes the vignette. While the image remains visible on the screen, respondents are asked to summarize, in their own words, the three key values (or types of public investments) emphasized in the text. This task is intended to maximize the treatment's priming effects. Respondents are then presented with the post-treatment questions.

In line with the previous surveys, I employ a forced-choice conjoint experiment to measure support for women's political leadership (Ofosu, Seeberg, and Wahman 2026). Respondents are presented with pairs of hypothetical political candidates and asked to choose which one they would prefer as their next leader. Each candidate profile is characterized by a set of randomly assigned attributes, including gender, age, ideology, political experience, and professional back-

ground. The key quantity of interest is the interaction between treatment assignment and the average marginal component effect (AMCE) of female candidacy.

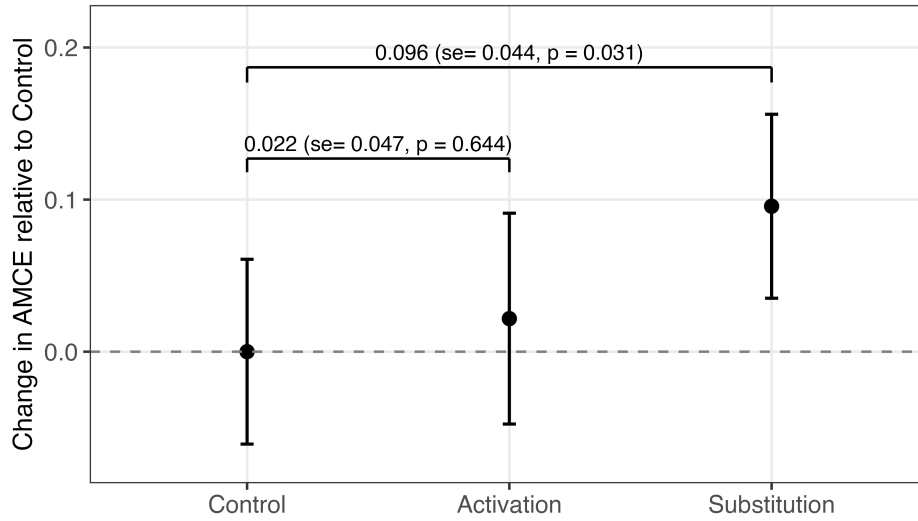
Results

The experiment in South Korea is scheduled to be fielded in the near term. Here, I report results from a pilot study fielded in the United States on June 11, 2026 ($N = 249$). Participants were recruited through Prolific, an online participant recruitment platform, and completed the survey programmed in Qualtrics. Because socialization within a geopolitical rivalry context is theorized to be an important pathway through which reservist values develop, I included a screener based on respondents' country of birth and nationality to restrict the U.S. sample accordingly. Gender quotas were applied to ensure an approximately equal distribution of men and women. To further improve response quality, participation was restricted to Prolific users with a prior approval rate between 95% and 100%. The pilot employed the same experimental procedures described above, with two differences. First, whereas the current design uses a vignette about infrastructure maintenance as the control condition, the pilot used a weather-related vignette as substantively unrelated content. Second, the pilot evaluated only the substitution and activation but not the reattribution treatment.

In the control condition, respondents showed a modest tendency to select male over female candidates ($\beta = -0.039, p = 0.211$). As shown in Figure 3, the substitution treatment produced a positive and statistically significant shift. Respondents in the substitution condition were 9.6 percentage points more likely to select female candidates relative to those in the control condition ($p = 0.031$), eliminating the gender penalty observed in the control group and reversing its direction toward a preference for female candidates. The activation treatment did not significantly alter this pattern. If anything, the positive direction of the coefficient suggests a slight reduction in the gender penalty relative to control, though this effect is far from statistically significant ($p = 0.644$).¹²

¹²Within the substitution condition, respondents were 5.7 percentage points more likely to select female candi-

Figure 3: The Effect of Reservist Values Activation and Substitution on Female Candidate Selection



Note: This figure presents the average marginal component effect (AMCE) of female candidacy in each treatment condition, expressed as a deviation from the control group estimate. Error bars represent 95% confidence intervals. Standard errors are clustered by respondent. All models control for candidate attributes (ideology, age, experience, and prior career) and task fixed effects.

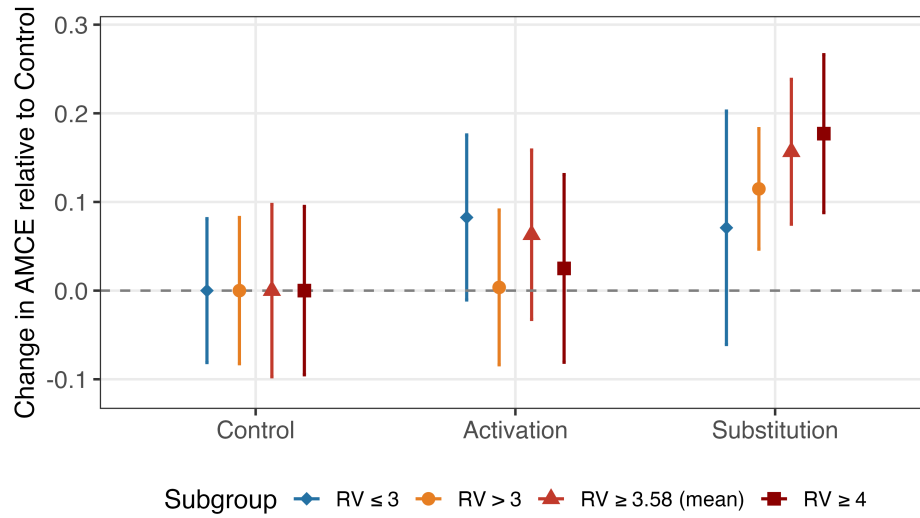
Next, I examine whether the treatment effects vary according to respondents' baseline reservist values. One approach would be to estimate a three-way interaction among treatment assignment, candidate gender, and pre-treatment reservist values. Given the limited sample size, however, such a specification would likely be underpowered. Instead, I rely on subgroup analyses, re-estimating the main models using a series of thresholds based on respondents' pre-treatment reservist values: (1) respondents with an average reservist value score of 3 or below ("slightly disagree" or lower), (2) respondents with a score greater than 3, (3) respondents with a score above the sample mean of 3.58, and (4) respondents with a score of 4 or above ("slightly agree" or higher). These thresholds progress from the weakest endorsers of reservist values to the strongest, allowing for an examination of whether treatment responsiveness shifts with the degree of prior reservist value commitment.

dates over male candidates. To assess whether this reversed preference is itself distinguishable from zero — rather than merely different from the control condition — a chi-square test was conducted on the combined female and interaction coefficients. This test indicates that the female preference within the substitution condition falls just short of conventional significance thresholds ($p = 0.067$).

Figure 4 presents the heterogeneous treatment effects across subgroups defined by pre-treatment reservist values. The substitution treatment produced consistently positive shifts across all subgroups, with the magnitude increasing with reservist value strength. Respondents with the lowest reservist values ($RV \leq 3$) showed the smallest shift, while those with the strongest reservist values ($RV \geq 4$) exhibited the largest, followed by $RV \geq 3.58$ and $RV > 3$. The consistent ordering across thresholds suggests that the *substitution treatment was most effective precisely among those who most strongly endorse reservist values*.

Among the activation treatment, respondents with lower reservist values ($RV \leq 3$) show the largest positive shift while those with higher reservist values ($RV > 3, \geq 3.58, \geq 4$) show progressively smaller and near-zero shifts. This can be interpreted as a backlash, where those who least endorse reservist values may have reacted against the overt emphasis on reservist identity in the activation vignette, increasing their preference for female candidates. Among those who already strongly endorse reservist values, the activation treatment had little effect.

Figure 4: Treatment Effects by Pre-Treatment Reservist Values



Note: This figure presents the average marginal component effect (AMCE) of female candidacy in each treatment condition, expressed as a deviation from the control group estimate. Error bars represent 95% confidence intervals. Standard errors are clustered by respondent. All models control for candidate attributes (ideology, age, experience, and prior career) and task fixed effects.

The overall pattern from the pilot provides preliminary evidence that the substitution treat-

ment increased the selection of female candidates. This effect was statistically significant in the full sample, and the subgroup analyses suggest that the positive shift was largest among respondents with stronger pre-treatment reservist values. By contrast, the activation treatment did not significantly reduce female candidate selection. Its effects were most positive among respondents with low pre-treatment reservist values, a pattern consistent with the possibility of backlash against the treatment message. This interpretation is also reflected in several open-ended responses, in which respondents associated the activation vignette with figures such as Trump and Hitler. Among respondents with stronger pre-treatment reservist values, activation produced little change in female candidate selection.

Discussion and Conclusion

A rich body of research has established that the security environment plays a critical role in shaping women's political representation (Barnes and O'Brien 2018; Hadzic and Tavits 2021b; Holman, Merolla, and Zechmeister 2022; Lawless 2004; Kang and Kim 2020). This study contributes to the existing literature by introducing an underexplored dimension of security: long-term geopolitical rivalry. I show that rivalry systematically reduces women's political representation, and that the adverse effects of sustained interstate hostility persist long after formal antagonism subsides.

Another central contribution of this article lies in the introduction of reservist values as a conceptual framework. Drawing on the Integrated Values Survey, I show that rivalry operates through a mechanism distinct from those identified in studies of acute security crises. Rather than heightening perceived threat, it cultivates deference to hierarchical authority, a sense of civic duty centered on national defense, and trust in state institutions. Each of these predispositions is associated with greater skepticism toward women's leadership. The study thus advances scholarly understanding of how geopolitical rivalry entrenches gender bias by cultivating reservist values. Finally, by presenting strategies to mitigate bias against women leaders, my work provide advocates and policymakers with a practical toolkit for expanding women's representation during

periods of external tension.

Importantly, these findings should not be read as suggesting that women are passive victims of geopolitical rivalry. Women have achieved substantial progress in political empowerment often despite significant structural and cultural constraints (Kreft and Schulz 2022; Lindsey and Koos 2024; Tripp 2023). The trajectories of former rivalry states themselves reflect this agency. As the GSC analysis shows, countries that exit rivalry eventually surpass their counterfactual paths in women's representation, reflecting the sustained efforts of women candidates, feminist movements, and institutional reforms to dismantle entrenched barriers. The contribution of this study is thus not to diminish these achievements, but to identify an underexamined structural condition that shapes the baseline difficulty of that process. Understanding this terrain is precisely what allows scholars, practitioners, and advocates to target the conditions that most effectively constrain women's political advancement.

This research points to several avenues for future inquiry. One important direction is to examine the transmission mechanisms through which rivalry cultivates reservist values, particularly the roles of education systems, media environments, and political rhetoric. Moreover, while this study explores heterogeneity by classifying rivalries according to their duration, future work could examine additional sources of variation, such as the historical origins of rivalries or the political and strategic characteristics of opposing states (Thompson, Sakuwa, and Suhas 2022). Although the main results indicate that rivalry's effects operate across varying levels of democratic consolidation, further research could assess whether similar dynamics emerge in non-democratic contexts.

Beyond the micro-level mechanism, institutional and elite-level pathways also offer an important direction for future research. While this study focuses on how rivalry shapes political culture and voter attitudes, it may also constrain women's representation through supply-side dynamics within parties and legislatures. Party gatekeepers may be less likely to recruit or nominate women in rivalry contexts, viewing them as electorally risky under sustained security competition (Kim and Kang 2022). Rivalry may also shape militarized legislative agendas that marginalize

women's policy concerns or reinforce masculine norms of political competence within elite networks (Kwon 2000). Institutional arrangements such as conscription policy, gender quotas, and education curricula may also condition the effects of rivalry by shaping gendered understandings of citizenship and leadership.¹³ Disentangling these demand and supply-side mechanisms, and their interaction across cultural, institutional, and elite levels, remains a promising avenue for future research.

Finally, future studies should develop and test additional strategies for mitigating the adverse consequences of hostile security environments for women's political representation. Although preventing terrorism, conflict, or geopolitical rivalry may be beyond the capacity of domestic actors, it is possible to strengthen the political and institutional conditions that sustain women's participation even under insecurity. Given the ample evidence that hostile security environments undermine women's representation (Itzkovitch-Malka 2024; Kim and Kang 2022; O'Brien and Piscopo 2023; Schroeder 2017), understanding what enables states to *maintain* or even *expand* women's representation during periods of external tension is essential for improving gender equality in an era of enduring global insecurity.

¹³Indeed, as shown in Appendix G, rivalry is associated with a significantly lower predicted probability that a country has a gender quota in place. Because the main models control for gender quotas, the estimated rivalry effect is not driven solely by quota differences; nevertheless, gender quotas may constitute one institutional pathway through which rivalry shapes women's representation.

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